



OwnCloud 3

A Cloud with a Silver Lining

We are all aware that storing data in the cloud has its own advantages, making our data available everywhere we go. But storing our personal data on someone else's server might lead to concerns about privacy. Check out the recently released ownCloud 3, which lets you host your data on your own server.

We've all used, or at least heard of, services like Dropbox, Ubuntu One or Box.Net, which allow us to store and sync our data in the cloud. This usually involves uploading our data to their servers (and purchasing more space, if we need to). It also comes with advantages like availability of our data from anywhere, and the ability to live-stream our media files when needed. But what if I tell you there is a cheaper and more privacy-oriented solution available, which offers similar features, and is also open source? Yes, that's ownCloud we're talking about. You can deploy ownCloud on your own server on a LAMP stack, or buy some cheap Web space and store your files. That is definitely cheaper than what most solutions provide. If it's only local intranet access that you want for sharing your files, look no further, because this is an ideal solution for that purpose.

The advantages of having ownCloud on your own server, instead of using services like Dropbox, is that you'll have more of a say about what you can store, and how much you can store. You are only limited by the amount of space you have left on your hard disk! What's more, you are responsible for your own data, so there are no privacy concerns about where/how your data is stored, and whether it is safe—somewhat like the Diaspora project in social networking.

What's new in ownCloud 3.0?

With the ownCloud application in active development, quite a few new features are available in the latest stable version. The use of open standards and protocols like webDAV, calDAV and cardDAV allows for the cross-platform availability of synchronisation without any problems. The text editor and photo

gallery are features that no other vendors provide. The PDF reader is an added bonus, and makes reading e-books and other documents easier. The calendar application makes more sense now that recurring events are available. You can now also install third-party applications for extended functionality within the Web application. Overall, when you compare this to the older versions, you'll see that the team has put in a lot of hard work.

Installation

Before going in for an install, you might want to check out the demo installation available online at demo.owncloud.org. It will give you a fair idea of what you are in for.

Installing ownCloud involves either getting it from your distribution's repository, or downloading it from www.owncloud.org and installing it manually, along with dependencies. The version available in the repositories is likely to be very old, so I suggest you try installing it yourself.

For our discussion, we'll be installing ownCloud 3, to get a taste of all those new features. The required dependencies can be installed in Ubuntu as follows:

```
sudo apt-get install apache2 php5 php5-json php5-gd php5-zip  
php5-mbstring php5-xml
```

In case of other distributions, you can figure out the equivalent commands. Also, these optional packages can be installed, depending on your choice of environment:

```
sudo apt-get install mp3info curl libcurl3 libcurl3-dev php5-curl  
zip php5-sqlite
```